



The Little Things

The psychological crime-thriller starring three Oscar winners is set to release on 29 January 2021. <http://digit.in/jan21-25>



Baumbach's New Netflix Project

Starring Greta Gerwig and Adam Driver, the family drama follows four siblings, each facing their own issues. <http://digit.in/jan21-26>



FABRICATING A WINTER WONDERLAND

Here's how Chicken Bone FX created New York City holiday magic in the Netflix show - "Dash & Lily"

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very year, around autumn fall, Netflix rolls out a fair lineup of Xmas-themed projects without fail.

And this year is no different, as we have a brand-new, young adult romantic comedy series based in New York City – Dash & Lily. Created by Joe Tracz, the eight-episode, half-hour show is an adaptation of the novel *Dash & Lily's Book of Dares* by David Levithan and Rachel Cohn. And follows the story of a cynical Dash and a cheerful Lily, as they trade dares, desires, secrets and

scavenger hunts, back and forth via a red notebook, that they hide in several locations around the holiday-embracing city, until they eventually fall in love.

What might come as a shocker to you is that the majority of the snow that you saw on-screen, wasn't even real! You see, the filming process on the show took place in 2019 fall and winter, on location, when the weather wasn't all that snowy. Flowers were still blossoming, tree leaves and bushes were bright green, and well... the skies were either sunny or raining. Since everyone dreams of a white Christmas, Netflix decided to hit up some long-time professionals in the field – Chicken Bone FX (CBFX). Having been in the business for over a decade, the company has worked on some pretty high-profile titles such as *Westworld*, *The Walking Dead*, *The Highwaymen* and quite recently, *The Queen's Gambit*, to name just a few. At Digit we're fans of some of those shows, so when we got the opportunity to chat with the VFX team about their latest project, we were ecstatic!

THE HOLIDAY SPIRIT

Creating the dazzling, and almost magical winter wonderland for the show, wasn't as easy as just slapping on a "snowfall filter" onto the raw footage. As stated by Gabriel Regentin (VFX Supervisor for Dash & Lily), there were quite a few steps that CBFX took, to make sure that the chilly, Big-Apple-Holiday-Experience was delivered in the best possible manner. Some of the techniques were extremely basic. Such as carefully planning the shoots around the ever-changing weather patterns. And directly working with the special effects team, to add practical on-set snow effects in desired locations. Back in the VFX offices, the artists would then add onto it, by messing around with digital matte paintings (DMPs) to further amplify the Christmassy feel. This would involve covering the streets, fences and building tops with snow, and adding brightly-lit Christmas decorations. Additionally, the team would add layers upon layers of DMP snowfall onto the footage, keeping depth perception in mind. This makes the snowfall feel 3-dimensional in a sense, where some of the flakes appear to be dropping behind the subject in focus, while the others float in between the camera lens and the subject. This creates a far more realistic snowfall effect, in comparison to one of those drag-and-drop filters that come inbuilt with certain video editing software.

Furthermore, Regentin mentioned that the DMPs and snow elements were often created in 2.5D, to allow perspective changes with scenes involving a moving camera. This makes the laden snow appear practical where, as the camera moves along, the elements would show new angles, develop shadows, and move closer or farther accordingly. "A great example of this is when Lily is walking up to Grand Central Station in episode 3. We covered sidewalks, tables, chairs, and the station itself with a blanket of 'fresh snow' using DMPs."

FADING VEGETATION

As the holiday season draws closer and closer, it leaves behind a saddening